

MATERIAL RANGE

STEEL
7,000
METRIC TONNES

CEMENT
35,000
METRIC TONNES (700,000 BAGS)

CONCRETE
60,000
CUBIC METRES

SAND
26,000
METRIC TONNES (4,000 LORRIES)

AGRA RED STONE
3,500
CUBIC METRES

BRICKS
100,000

the CM, has been provided for. Besides this, every floor has three meeting halls for use by ministers and senior officials.

The lower ground floor has been designed for services and arrival lobbies, apart from entry and exit points. The building has an imposing entrance, with a three-storey-high arrival portico, while the atrium will have Telangana mural art and an LED wall showcasing development in the state.

The business of the secretariat is conducted through 29 administrative departments, each headed by a secretary with his support staff. Existing guidelines on per capita space allocation were modified to meet modern requirements in terms of working space and amenities. Fire tenders, parking, vehicular and pedestrian movement and external services such as hydrants, drainages, storm water flow and security installations are also provided for in a comprehensive manner. A terrain modelling technique was also employed to ensure inundation-free topography.

Planning, specifications and various estimates were made while meeting tendering deadlines. The R&B department ensured that every worker was fully vaccinated against Covid-19 and provided precaution doses on site.

Gleaming domes that emerge, one by one, over the secretariat perimeter screened by high walls and huge sheets that virtually veil the goings on, may suggest the building will be ready by Dussehra. But fabricating and erecting the 34 composite steel and cement domes and installing them with cranes is time-consuming and challenging. Nine domes are yet to be installed, including the two massive, 50-feet in diameter central domes, to be placed atop a 48-feet-long cylindrical drum at a height of 165 feet. For on-site construction engineers, it is a rare engineering experience—tying of the reinforcement, shuttering, back propping and laying concrete.

KCR, bowing to pressure, has agreed to build a temple and mosque, which existed in the old secretariat premises, anew. A church is also coming up. These and other utilities, like buildings for visitors, police, fire services and a crèche will come up in the area beyond the rectangular complex. The total cost is expected to rise from Rs 615 crore to over Rs 800 crore.

Though KCR believes a new state secretariat is a matter of pride for Telangana, political opponents say it is a misplaced priority and only panders to his self-image as being the sole builder of modern Telangana. They point out that his promise to move all state-level offices into the secretariat is impossible for want of space—the different directorates will continue to be outside the secretariat. A plan to put up another large building nearby with an underground tunnel connecting it to the secretariat is on the backburner.

Unfazed by such talk, KCR is eager to get the secretariat up and running by Sankranti in mid-January and move into this monumental seat of power before calling for an assembly election later in the year. It's now a race to the finish in Hyderabad. ■